

UNIFIED STORAGE TO HELP MANAGE DATA

Running on a single storage platform instead of multiple servers running on various platforms, unified data storage appliances let enterprises effectively manage their storage needs



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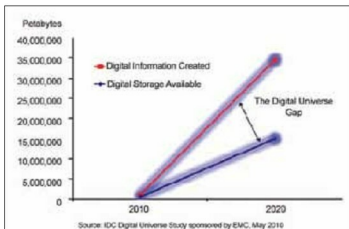
We are in the midst of a digital revolution that is changing the way we communicate, work and live. This, in turn, has had significant ramifications on how we produce, store and recall information, almost every bit of which is becoming digitised.

Collectively, we are on pace to churn out 35 zettabytes, or 35 trillion gigabytes, of information by 2020. To put this in perspective, if each piece of digital information were a DVD, the stack of DVDs would then reach halfway to Mars.

We are creating so much digital content that we have already exceeded the amount of digital storage space available. An estimate says that we

would have a shortfall of around 35 per cent if we tried to store every single piece of digital data created in 2009. This gap will only increase over time (see the figure).

Given this, it is critical that we have



Gap between digital information created and digital storage available will only increase with time

a reliable, cost-effective and scalable storage solution in the form of an easily managed unified storage platform.

Why unified storage

Traditional servers have become very expensive as a long-term solution, especially when factoring in the costs of the equipment and software licences and also the need for management by a network administrator. In recent years, a new class of storage solutions which consolidates network-attached storage (NAS) appliances and storage area networks has become readily available. These storage appliances run on a single storage platform instead of multiple servers running on various platforms, providing enterprises with reliable, scalable and easy-to-use tools to effectively manage their storage needs.

High reliability. Given the growing dependence on digital information for business transactions, a single minute of downtime has direct impact on the revenue of a company. For a company like Taobao that processes all of its transactions via its website, losing one minute of uptime can cost the company \$36,000, or roughly \$2 million, per hour.

Taobao selected a unified storage platform with active-active node configuration that could survive single- or multiple-node fail-